CHAPTER 7 :

MARKETING IRON MAN

Spider-Man. Superman. Batman. Wolverine and the X-Men. These are all comic-book characters that exist at the forefront of the pop-culture zeitgeist. Utter the names of any of these legendary super heroes, and their iconic stature instantly pops into the minds of the average person. After decades of ruling the comic-book sales charts and the ratings of animated and live-action TV fare, these icons hardly had anything further to prove to their fans before they were turned into blockbuster films. And naturally, when big-budget films were eventually made, long lines of crowds queued up to see them, launching successful franchises that still exist to this day.

The aphorism "build it and they will come" may explain a decent proportion of the aforementioned icons' movie success, but it's not the kind of thing that producers lining up a multimillion-dollar budget are going to put all their faith into. On the contrary, besides making a solid movie, the question foremost in a producer's mind is "How are we going to market this thing?" A question easily answered for heroes to whom the public needs no introduction. But Iron Man, as it turns out, was not such a character.A cool-looking super hero with awesome powers and a compelling backstory? Absolutely! But a recognizable icon? Even after 45 years of success in the comic-book world, hardly. Aside from a brief run as a Saturday-morning cartoon in the swinging late '60s, the heroic alter ego of Tony Stark has rarely – if ever – tickled the frontal lobe of pop-culture consciousness.

Enter the movie-marketing pros at Paramount. After the movie was complete and its producers were anxiously waiting to see the fruits of their success up on the screen, it was up to the mavens of the marketing department to work their magic. And a lot was depending on them doing it right. For even though the movie was ostensibly about a billionaire genius in a basement garage crafting a world-beating suit of flying armor, movie marketers couldn't afford to take a "build it and they will come" attitude when promoting the movie. Indeed, in a marketplace more crowded than ever with tales of super-heroic suspense, the marketing of *Iron Man* was going to have be performed with feats every bit as heroic as those that had come before.

